

Race of a LIFETIME

The definitive book on the most audacious political journey in American history



THE BRIDGE: THE
LIFE AND RISE OF
BARACK OBAMA

by DAVID REMNICK

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| By S. Prasannarajan |

The O!-ba-ma phase is over. Too much sunlight has fallen on the mystique and what we have in the place of the erstwhile American Catharsis is the 44th President of the United States who, like any other mortal who preceded him, is caught between the mercilessness of reality and the last remains of hope. On the completion of his one year in the White House, which was built by slaves two centuries before the campaign of America's first black president, he said in a press conference that the "justifiable pride" in his historic election had "lasted about a day." Then he voluntarily came out of his own mythology and admitted: "Right now, the American people are judging me exactly the way I should be judged." His performance, particularly in the context of his healthcare reform, which heralded the return of the welfare state in its most inflated Leftist avatar, only brought out the worst bipartisan instincts of American politics.

The great unifier—and the Reconciler-in-Chief—saw his own migration from the romance of his candidature to the realism of a world he has inherited. He set a time-table for the withdrawal of American troops from the "phoney" war of Mesopotamia and committed more firepower to the just war of Afghanistan, though at both places, the living legacy of George Bush's moral activism, a final resolution is still a fantasy. He promised the closure of Guantanamo within a year but the monument to Bush's Manichean worldview was not that easy to be demolished. Elsewhere, when the streets erupted in Tehran for freedom from the thuggery of Ahmadinejad, the leader of the free world was hardly unequivocal in his

support for the martyrs. Forget all that, his fan club argued, and think of his socialist intervention that saved America from the brink of a recession. Then the arbiters at Oslo honoured him with the Nobel Peace Prize—and he was not even one year old as President. It was a prize for not being George Bush. "It was not helpful to us politically," Obama told David Remnick, "although Axelrod and I joke about it, the one thing we didn't anticipate this year was having to apologize for having won the Nobel Peace Prize."

Obama can still joke about himself—and the



AP presidential cool is almost intact. And Obamology, in spite of his de-mythified presidency, continues to be a chosen discipline for historians and journalists. Remnick, a Pulitzer winner and the editor of *The New Yorker*, is one of America's finest practitioners of long-form narrative journalism. His *Lenin's Tomb* still ranks among the best books that capture the dying days of the Soviet empire. *The Bridge*, his deconstruction of a much

deconstructed phenomenon, is more than an appreciation and a homage despite the fact that Remnick, like many of his colleagues, too has been swayed by Force Obama in the racial history of America. It is the magnified image of a man who turned the oldest cliché in politics—change—into a defining motif in the narrative of national redemption: "Obama would make his biracial ancestry a metaphor for his ambition to create a broad coalition of support, to rally Americans behind a narrative of moral and political progress. He was not necessarily the hero of that narrative, but he just might be its culmination." He would indeed become its hero, and his life